

Additional References: "Two Men, One Gospel"

Braselton SDA Sermon — Research & Source File

I. Ellen White — Full Source List

Acts of the Apostles (1911)

The primary EGW source for this sermon. Key passages:

- **p. 455** — Demas's departure: "For worldly gain, Demas bartered every high and noble consideration. How shortsighted the exchange! Possessing only worldly wealth or honor, Demas was poor indeed, however much he might proudly call his own."
- **p. 490** — Luke's faithfulness at Rome: "The services of Luke, the beloved disciple and faithful friend, were a great comfort to Paul and enabled him to communicate with his brethren and the world without."
- **p. 547** — Ephesus and lost first love: "The church of Ephesus had let slip her first love. She was more intent on carrying on the forms and ceremonies of religion than on possessing its spirit. She was more anxious to win the approval of men than to win the approval of God."
- **p. 544–547** — Full Ephesus section. White connects the activity of the Ephesian church to the hollowness of works without love. Worth reading the surrounding pages.
- **p. 482–490** — White's full account of Paul's Roman imprisonment and Luke's presence. Provides narrative color for the sermon's opening scene.

Testimonies for the Church

- **Vol. 5, p. 161** — Business crowding out prayer and Scripture: "Many are so absorbed in business that they have no time for prayer, no time for the study of the Bible... The cares of this life crowd out the things of eternity."
- **Vol. 4, pp. 86–88** — Laodicean condition and the eyesalve. White describes the Holy Spirit as the spiritual vision that restores sight to a church grown comfortable. "The gold tried in the fire is faith and love. The white raiment is the righteousness of Christ. The eyesalve is the true spiritual discernment that is so wanting among us."

Steps to Christ (1892)

- **p. 44** — Love as the motive for discipleship: "It is not so much the fear of punishment, or the hope of everlasting reward, that leads the disciples of Christ to follow Him. They behold the Saviour's matchless love... and to them duty becomes a delight and sacrifice a pleasure."
- **p. 47** — "Love is the basis of godliness. Whatever the profession, no man has pure love to God unless he has unselfish love for his brother."

Education (1903)

- **p. 57** — The greatest want: "The greatest want of the world is the want of men—men who will not be bought or sold, men who are as true to duty as the needle to the pole, men who will stand for the right though the heavens fall."

The Great Controversy (1888)

- **p. 508** — Satan's strategy of distraction through distortion of God's character.

- **p. 601–602** — Laodicean self-satisfaction and spiritual blindness at the end of time. White sees Laodicea not as a historical curiosity but as a prophetic portrait of the final-generation church.

The Desire of Ages (1898)

- **p. 392** — The principle behind Luke 9:23: "The life of Christ was a life of constant self-denial and self-sacrifice." Use to illuminate what it means that Luke (writer of the Gospel) then lived out its words.
- **p. 668–672** — The restoration of Peter (John 21:15–17). White's account of Jesus's threefold question to Peter illuminates why *love* — not performance — is the center of discipleship. "Jesus did not ask Peter if he loved Him better than did other men. He did not ask if his love was unselfish or his faith perfect... He simply asked, 'Lovest thou Me?'"

Messages to Young People (1930)

- **p. 98** — "Many of our young people are being absorbed in outside enterprises and amusements. Their thoughts are upon worldly things; and when they enter the house of God, they are not in a condition of mind to receive divine instruction." (Contextual application for any young-adult segment.)

Review and Herald Articles

- **June 7, 1887** — White on the cooling of first love: "The first affection of the convert to Christ is deep, full, and ardent... God sees that there is not heart service, a love for Jesus, an earnest zeal in his work." (Used in prior outlines — verify exact text before quoting.)

II. Biblical Commentaries and Scholarship

On 2 Timothy 4:10 (Demas)

- *William Barclay, *The Daily Study Bible: The Letters to Timothy, Titus, and Philemon* (1975) — Barclay notes that the Greek phrase *agapēsas ton nun aiōna** carries enormous weight: Demas gave to the world the very love that should have been given to God. He also observes that Demas may have originally been a Thessalonian (he returns there), which suggests the pull of home, family, and established life — not simply moral failure.
- *N.T. Wright, *Paul for Everyone: The Pastoral Letters* (2003)* — Wright reads Demas as a cautionary portrait of what happens when the eschatological urgency fades. When people stop feeling that this world is passing away, they start optimizing for it.
- *F.F. Bruce, *The Epistles to the Colossians, to Philemon, and to the Ephesians* (NICNT, 1984)* — Bruce traces Demas through all three canonical appearances and notes the descent from "fellow laborer" to unnamed departure. He emphasizes that Paul does not pronounce judgment — only names the fact of departure and its cause.
- *Philip Towner, *The Letters to Timothy and Titus* (NICNT, 2006)* — Towner's commentary on 2 Timothy 4:10 notes the passive-voice quality of the abandonment: Demas did not dramatically storm out. He simply was no longer there. The drift was quiet.

On Luke's Character and Role

- *I. Howard Marshall, *The Gospel of Luke* (NIGTC, 1978)* — Introduction discusses Luke as historian, physician, and traveling companion. His "we" passages (Acts 16:10–17; 20:5–21:18; 27:1–28:16) trace the itinerary of a man who chose proximity to Paul over security.
- *Richard Bauckham, *Jesus and the Eyewitnesses* (2006)* — Notes that Luke's practice of naming himself only through "we" (never "I" or by name) reflects a deliberate authorial humility. He is present but not the point. This is theologically significant for the sermon's application.
- *John Nolland, *Luke 1–9:20* (WBC, 1989) — *Commentary on Luke 9:23 ("take up his cross daily") highlights the word kath' hēmeran** — "daily." The cross is not a one-time event but a daily reorientation. Luke recorded these words; Luke lived them.

On Revelation 2:4–5 (Ephesus / First Love)

- *G.K. Beale, *The Book of Revelation* (NIGTC, 1999)* — Beale's commentary notes that the Ephesian church's abandonment of first love is not explicitly defined as a doctrinal failure — it is an affective and relational failure. The church remained orthodox but lost intimacy. This is precisely the Demas parallel.
- *Grant Osborne, *Revelation* (BECNT, 2002)* — The three commands in Revelation 2:5 (remember, repent, do the first works) are sequential and intentional. Memory precedes repentance; repentance precedes action. You cannot return to what you cannot name.

On the Laodicean Letter (Revelation 3:15–18)

- *Colin Hemer, The Letters to the Seven Churches of Asia (1986)* — Hemer's archaeological research establishes that Laodicea received water via aqueduct from hot springs — by the time it arrived, it was lukewarm. Christ's metaphor was locally devastating. The church could not miss the reference.
- **Beale (above)** — The Laodicean letter ends with Christ standing *outside* the door (Rev 3:20), knocking to enter. The imagery suggests that the problem is not that the church has left Christ — but that Christ has been gradually moved out of the center of a church still using his name.

III. Historical / Background Material

The Setting of 2 Timothy

- Paul is in his second Roman imprisonment, c. AD 67. Unlike his first imprisonment (house arrest, Acts 28), this is a dungeon cell. Execution under Nero is imminent. The letter is written with full awareness that it may be the last.
- The list of departures in 2 Timothy 4:9–12 is striking: Demas, Crescens, Titus, Tychicus have all departed (for various reasons). Carpus is in Troas. Alexander has become an adversary. In this context, "only Luke is with me" is not a casual notation — it is a pastoral testimony under duress.
- **Source:** Everett Ferguson, *Backgrounds of Early Christianity* (3rd ed., 2003), pp. 556–560 — Context of Neronian persecution and the precarity of Christian association.

Luke as Physician in the First-Century World

- Physicians in the Roman world occupied a respected but itinerant professional class. They were often freedmen or Greek-educated practitioners. Luke's education and profession gave him genuine economic mobility — he was not trapped with Paul.
- His choice to remain with a condemned prisoner was therefore not passive or default. It was active.
Source: Vivian Nutton, *Ancient Medicine* (2004), ch. 11.

The Colossians-Laodicea Connection

- Colossians 4:16: "And when this epistle is read among you, cause that it be read also in the church of the Laodiceans." Paul names both Demas and Luke in Colossians — and then instructs the letter to travel to Laodicea. The Laodicean church that Christ addresses in Revelation 3 likely received this very letter. The connection is not forced: Demas's name traveled to Laodicea in the same scroll that warned them about spiritual complacency.
- **Source:** N.T. Wright, *Colossians and Philemon* (TNTC, 1986), pp. 156–160.

IV. Adventist-Specific Resources

Prophetic Context

- The Laodicean diagnosis (Revelation 3:14–18) holds special significance in Adventist ecclesiology. Ellen White applies it directly to the Adventist church as a description of the end-time condition of God's people — not enemies of God, but people who have become comfortable and self-sufficient.
- **Source:** White, E.G. *Testimonies for the Church*, Vol. 3, pp. 252–261 — Extended Laodicean application to the post-1844 Adventist community.
- **Source:** White, E.G. *Testimonies for the Church*, Vol. 4, pp. 86–88 — The eyesalve prescription.

The Sabbath as Anti-Drift Mechanism

(Developed in the vespers presentation; can be briefly referenced in the sermon if time allows)

- "The Sabbath is God's built-in resistance against becoming Demas." — from Atlanta North Vespers, 2025.
- Sabbath interrupts the *ai■n* — the present age's rhythm of productivity and acquisition — and reorients the worshiper to the person of Christ. It is relational, not merely regulatory.
- **Source:** Abraham Heschel, *The Sabbath* (1951) — while not Adventist, Heschel's language of Sabbath as "a sanctuary in time" complements the theological point without requiring citation in the sermon.

V. Sermon Illustration Bank

The Gradual Drift Illustration

A ship that loses anchor does not announce its departure from port. It simply moves — slowly, almost imperceptibly — until the distance becomes irreversible. The sailor who sleeps through the drift wakes to find the shore has disappeared. Demas did not announce a departure. He simply arrived somewhere else.

The Marriage Illustration (from prior outlines)

A marriage does not usually collapse because of a single catastrophic event. It cools through the daily, incremental substitution of other things — career, comfort, distraction — for the daily intentional acts of love. The affection is not destroyed; it is displaced.

The Medical Illustration (Chukwuma's physician voice)

In medicine, we distinguish between acute and chronic conditions. An acute MI — a heart attack — announces itself. Chest pain, diaphoresis, radiation to the jaw. No one misses it. But coronary artery disease — the underlying process — is silent for decades. Plaque builds. Vessels narrow. Perfusion drops. By the time the acute event arrives, the chronic process has been underway for years. Demas did not have an acute spiritual event. He had a chronic condition of the soul. The departure from Paul was the myocardial infarction. The drift from Christ had been underway long before.

The Lottery Ticket Illustration (from prior outlines)

A man who sells a winning lottery ticket worth millions for a single meal because he is momentarily hungry. The meal satisfies for an hour. The loss is permanent. Demas sold his eternal inheritance for the fleeting security of a worldly arrangement.

The "Only" Illustration

There are moments in a person's life when everyone who could be there is not there. The hospital room at 2 a.m. The prison cell. The final letter. In those moments, the person who stays becomes — in that moment — the entire body of Christ to the person suffering. Luke was not a superhero. He was simply present. And "only Luke" was enough. You never know when your staying will be someone's only.

VI. Suggested Hymns (SDA Hymnal)

- **#309 — "I Surrender All"** — Response hymn; fits the "love question" close
- **#618 — "Lead On, O King Eternal"** — Opening processional; theme of faithful endurance
- **#590 — "Trust and Obey"** — Reinforces the Luke disposition
- **#326 — "Open My Eyes, That I May See"** — Fits the Laodicean eyesalve section if referenced
- **# 8 — "We Gather Together"** (Sabbath opening) — Community framing

VII. Further Reading for Sermon Preparation

1. **Barclay, William.** *The Daily Study Bible: The Letters to Timothy, Titus, and Philemon.* Westminster Press, 1975.
2. **Beale, G.K.** *The Book of Revelation.* Eerdmans (NIGTC), 1999.
3. **Bruce, F.F.** *The Epistles to the Colossians, to Philemon, and to the Ephesians.* Eerdmans (NICNT), 1984.
4. **Ferguson, Everett.** *Backgrounds of Early Christianity.* 3rd ed. Eerdmans, 2003.
5. **Hemer, Colin.** *The Letters to the Seven Churches of Asia.* Sheffield Academic Press, 1986.
6. **Marshall, I. Howard.** *The Gospel of Luke.* Eerdmans (NIGTC), 1978.
7. **Towner, Philip.** *The Letters to Timothy and Titus.* Eerdmans (NICNT), 2006.
8. **White, Ellen G.** *The Acts of the Apostles.* Review & Herald, 1911. [pp. 455, 482–490, 544–547]
9. **White, Ellen G.** *Steps to Christ.* Review & Herald, 1892. [pp. 44, 47]
10. **White, Ellen G.** *Testimonies for the Church.* Vol. 4, pp. 86–88; Vol. 5, p. 161.
11. **Wright, N.T.** *Paul for Everyone: The Pastoral Letters.* Westminster John Knox, 2003.
12. **Wright, N.T.** *Colossians and Philemon.* Eerdmans (TNTC), 1986.